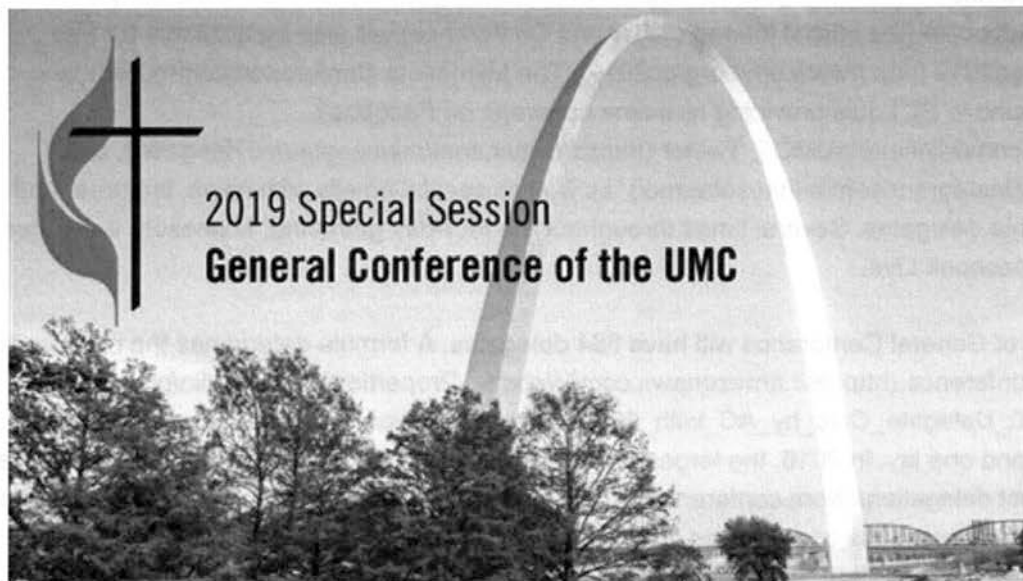


10 things to know about General Conference 2019

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By: Christa Meland

Later this month (Feb. 23-26), United Methodist delegates from around the world will gather in St. Louis, Missouri for a special session of General Conference. This special session will focus on human

sexuality and church unity.

The purpose will be to receive and act on a report from the Commission on a Way Forward (<http://www.umc.org/who-we-are/commission-on-a-way-forward>). This 32-member Commission was authorized by the 2016 General Conference and appointed by the Council of Bishops to examine paragraphs in *The Book of Discipline* concerning human sexuality (<http://www.umc.org/topics/topic-human-sexuality-homosexuality>) and how to be in ministry with LGBTQI people, and to explore options to strengthen the unity of the church.

Here are 10 important things you should know about the upcoming General Conference:

1. Four delegates will represent the Minnesota Conference at the gathering—Revs. Judy Zabel and Woojae Im, along with Faye Christensen and Dave Nuckols (who served on the Commission on a Way Forward). Eight reserve delegates will also attend the gathering: Revs. Carol Zaagsma, Jeff Ozanne, Amy Jo Bur, and Paula Colton, along with Leslie Hobson, Walker Brault, Karen Thompson, and Shirley Durr.

2. Inevitably, some people will be pleased with the decisions that delegates make (or don't make), and others will be disappointed by them. Whatever happens, the ministry to which we are called—making disciples of Jesus Christ for the transformation of the world—will continue. Let us make space for each

other's grief, relief, fear, anxiety, hurt, and disappointment, and let us remember that God is with us and God's mission is yet alive.

3. The Sunday after the 2019 General Conference (March 3) is Transfiguration Sunday. The Minnesota Conference's Human Sexuality Task Force, appointed by Bishop Bruce R. Ough, has compiled an outstanding set of worship resources to be used that day. The resources—which include lectionary scriptures, prayer and liturgies, and sermon ideas—are intended to “combine the liturgical recognition of Transfiguration Sunday with food for the heart and soul regardless of the outcome” of General Conference. View resources ([/files/resources-transfiguration+sunday+2019.docx](#))

4. There are several ways you can follow along with what's happening at General Conference. The special session will be live-streamed at [UMC.org/gc2019](http://www.umc.org/gc2019) (<http://www.umc.org/gc2019>). Copies of the daily editions of the Daily Christian Advocate (the official journal of General Conference) will also be available for free download at [UMC.org/gc2019](http://www.umc.org/gc2019) (<http://www.umc.org/gc2019>). The Minnesota Conference communications team will be on the ground in St. Louis providing real-time coverage on Facebook (<https://www.facebook.com/MinnesotaUMC/>), Twitter (<https://twitter.com/minnesotaumc?lang=en>), and Instagram (<https://www.instagram.com/minnesotaumc/>), as well as special emails with news, features, and reactions from Minnesota delegates. Several times throughout the four-day gathering, Minnesota delegates will give updates via Facebook Live.

5. The special session of General Conference will have 864 delegates. A formula determines the number of delegates from each conference (http://s3.amazonaws.com/Website_Properties/news-media/press-center/documents/2020_Delegate_Calc_by_AC_with_2016_comp.pdf). Every conference is guaranteed at least two—one clergy and one lay. In 2016, the largest delegations came from North Katanga (48) and Côte d'Ivoire (34). The largest delegations from conferences in the United States were from Virginia and Western North Carolina (22 each). Most of the conferences in Europe and the Philippines had two delegates, as did nine in the United States. Each conference elects an equal number of clergy and laity.

6. The Commission on a Way Forward presented three plans (two of which it authored) that are at the core of what will be discussed and considered by delegates: the One-Church Plan, the Connectional Conferences Plan, and the Traditionalist Plan. The Council of Bishops is recommending the One-Church Plan. Learn more about all three plans (<https://www.minnesotaumc.org/newsdetail/a-way-forward-the-three-plans-and-resources-for-churches-11499165>)

7. Delegates will pray, worship, and fellowship together—but they will begin with a full day of prayer (<http://www.umc.org/who-we-are/praying-our-way-forward-team-unveils-details-of-february-23-day-of-prayer?fbclid=IwAR04mGRnbQKeluh5xOUUE5C0JWFLc72gjlVj4ORPMMTB1uWrlb1g7SpvW4>). After that, they will spend most of their time listening, deliberating, discussing, and voting on legislation. At this special session, delegates will vote on motions and amendments on petitions included in three plans in the Commission on a Way Forward report (http://s3.amazonaws.com/Website_Properties/council-of-bishops/news_and_statements/documents/Way_Forum_Report_-_Final_-_ENGLISH.pdf) and other petitions from individuals and groups of United Methodists. Fifty-one petitions, besides those included in the Commission's report, were submitted by the deadline. Delegates will use electronic, smartcard-enabled devices to cast their secret ballots and to request recognition to address the assembly.

8. Bishops convene and preside over plenary sessions and lead worship services, but they have neither voice nor vote at General Conference—meaning they have no role in deciding what does or does not get

adopted.

9. The Advance Daily Christian Advocate (ADCA) contains the agenda, rules, delegate listings, petitions, reports from the general agencies/commissions and study committees, information for delegates, and codes of conduct for the 2019 General Conference. If you want to get a better sense for exactly what delegates will be doing and discussing, that resource is worth exploring. Read Advance Daily Christian Advocate (http://cdnfiles.umc.org/Website_Properties/general-conference/2019/documents/general-conference-2019-adca-english.pdf)

10. If you or members of your congregation want to learn more about General Conference, United Methodist Communications is offering a free online course. This self-directed online course uses short articles, quizzes, and multimedia interactions to provide information about what General Conference is, shed light on its historical roots, and show how church policies are made within the context of this global gathering. Learn more (<https://www.umctraining.org/product?catalog=EG-Conference>)

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Council of Bishops
THE UNITED METHODIST CHURCH



Friday, December 28, 2018

To our Global LGBTQ Kin in Christ,

The Council of Bishops of The United Methodist Church recognizes the ways in which the convening of the Special Session of General Conference creates a time and space of harm for you and members of your family. To be the focus of attention, discussion and debate is hurtful.

Demeaning and dehumanizing comments and attacks on LGBTQ persons in conversations related to the upcoming February Conference are a great tragedy and do violence to hearts, minds, and spirits. When you suffer, the whole body of Christ suffers. Together, we need to work to resist hate, violence, and oppression of persons. In these attitudes and actions, great harm is done throughout the community, to the offended and the offender.

As Paul wrote in 1 Corinthians 12: We cannot say to a part of the body, "I have no need of you." We belong to each other. In our Baptism, we are incorporated into the Church, the body of Christ, and made one in Christ. The Church pledges to every baptized member: "Your joy, your pain, your gain, your loss, are ours, for you are one of us." (*The UMC Book of Worship*, pg. 83). Our Book of Discipline clearly states that all people are of sacred worth.

As leaders of the church, we are brokenhearted by conversations that dishonor, objectify and dehumanize. We confess, as Bishops of The United Methodist Church and as we attempt to honor our convictions, that our actions and words have not always been life-giving or honoring of the LGBTQ community. Amid our sorrow, we seek to learn and grow in grace. To that end, we commit ourselves to helping people who disagree with each other to have conversations that include, honor, and respect people with different convictions. We are a diverse group of leaders—conservative, centrist, progressive—however, we are unified in our commitment to work together in ways that will give you and all God's children strength, comfort and hope for better and more merciful tomorrows.

As the Special Session of General Conference approaches, we pray that the Holy Spirit will draw us together. May we see the image of God in one another, treat one another with tenderness, and love one another fiercely. Bearing Christ's love in these ways, we pray to be God's faithful witnesses.

The Council of Bishops
The United Methodist Church

Overview of Plans to 2019 General Conference

	One Church Plan	Connectional Conference Plan	Traditional/Modified Traditional Plan	Simple Plan
Summary	- Removes "incompatible with Christian teaching" statement from some paragraphs (Social Principles, ¶¶ 304, 310, 2702) and adds to new paragraphs (¶¶ 415, 605) - Removes prohibitions against same-gender weddings and ordination of "self-avowed practicing homosexuals" - Adds protections for bishops and clergy who choose not to officiate at ordinations or weddings - Effective Jan 1, 2020 – extends time for central conferences to 18 months after General Conference	- Replaces the current geographical jurisdictional with three connectional conferences based on perspectives on sexuality: Progressive, Traditional and Unity - Additional conferences may be established to a maximum of eight. - Each would use a general Book of Discipline with the ability to adapt other portions to their context for ministry. - Requires constitutional amendments - Implementation not complete until 2025	- Maintains prohibitions against self-avowed practicing gay clergy and same-gender weddings - Broadens the definition of "self-avowed practicing homosexual" to include persons living in a same-sex marriage or civil union or persons who publicly state that they are practicing homosexuals. - Mandates penalties for disobedience to the Discipline - Requires bishops, pastors and annual conferences to certify adherence to the Discipline standards on LGBTQ marriage and ordination - Effective at the adjournment of the 2019 special session	- Removes incompatibility clause - Eliminates all prohibitions that limit the role of homosexual people in the church - Effective Jan 1, 2020 with an additional 12 months for central conferences
Local Churches	- May establish wedding policies to allow or forbid same-gender weddings - Not required to have LGBTQ pastor – preference will be considered in making appointments - Maintains current process for churches that seek to leave	- Churches in the Unity Conference may establish wedding policies that allow or prohibit same-gender weddings - Can vote to join a connectional conference other than the one chosen by their annual conference - Property, assets and liabilities retained if church votes to join a different conference	- Can vote to stay or leave the UMC if disagrees with annual conference's decision - Can leave with property	- Allows, but does not require, same-gender weddings in churches - Not required to have LGBTQ pastor – preference will be considered in making appointments - Maintains current process for churches that seek to leave
Clergy	- Allowed, but not required, to perform same-gender weddings - Bishop & cabinet would take theological convictions into account for appointments - LGBTQ candidates can be ordained and appointed to local churches that approve and can request transfer of candidacy if conference Board of	- Can request to affiliate with a connectional conference other than the one chosen by their annual conference - Transfers subject to approval by the receiving Board of Ordained Ministry and clergy session - Ordination recognized across all three connectional conferences	- Must uphold the Discipline's standards on LGBTQ marriage and ordination or join "autonomous, affiliated, or concordat" church - Just resolutions from complaints must include commitment not to repeat offense - First offense results in one-year unpaid suspension	- Can discern whether to officiate at any wedding - Permitted to be married in accordance with civil law - Retains shared fidelity in marriage

Overview of Plans to 2019 General Conference

	One Church Plan	Connectional Conference Plan	Traditional/Modified Traditional Plan	Simple Plan
	Ordained Ministry or clergy session chooses not to ordain LGBTQ persons. Retains standard of celibacy in singleness and fidelity in marriage.	Security of appointment determined by connectional conferences	Second offense results in surrendering credentials	
Annual Conferences	- Boards of ordained ministry and/or clergy session can discern whether to ordain LGBTQ persons - Assist clergy who do not support conference standards to transfer - Not required to accept transfer of LGBTQ clergy - No change required for central conferences. The ability to adapt Disciplinary language continues.	- Jurisdictional and central conferences vote by simple majority to determine connectional conference relationship. Central conferences may vote to affiliate with one of the three proposed conferences, create a new connectional conference or declare their central conference a connectional conference. - Annual conferences can vote to join a connectional conference other than the one chosen by their jurisdictional or central conference.	- Required to certify that it will uphold, enforce, and maintain the Discipline's standards on LGBTQ marriage and ordination - Those that do not certify urged to form an "autonomous, affiliated, or concordat church" and can't use United Methodist name or logo nor receive funds in 2021 - Provides \$200,000 grant to annual conferences that leave (Modified)	- Boards of ordained ministry and/or clergy session can discern whether to ordain LGBTQ persons - No change required for central conferences. The ability to adapt Disciplinary language continues.
Bishops	- Assignments will reflect convictions of bishops and annual conferences - Protects bishops if conscience will not allow him or her to ordain, license or commission LGBTQ persons	- Each bishop, active and retired, chooses a connectional conference - Oversight and accountability falls to bishops of each connectional conference - Funded by U.S. connectional conferences at comparable levels, with shared funding, as needed, for bishops outside the U.S. - All episcopal elections would take place by 2022.	- Requires all bishops to certify that they will uphold and enforce Discipline standards on LGBTQ marriage and ordination. - Active bishops who do not certify ineligible to receive compensation for expenses as of 2021 and encouraged to join "autonomous, affiliated, or concordat" church - Strengthens accountability process - Creates global episcopacy committee (Modified)	May ordain and appoint LGBTQ candidates
General Agencies	- No proposed changes in current structure or operations - Retains prohibition against funding promotion of homosexuality	- Wespath, Publishing House, Archives and History, GCFA, Faith and Order, UMCOR and parts of GBGM jointly funded to continue. - Task force evaluates general agencies and proposes new model by 2025	- All general agencies continue - Each agency can contract with churches that leave the UMC	May fund ministries with LGBTQ persons

Overview of Plans to 2019 General Conference

	One Church Plan	Connectional Conference Plan	Traditional/Modified Traditional Plan	Simple Plan
		In new model, agencies are funded by and serve only participating connectional conferences		
Related Institutions	No changes	- Properties owned by annual conference and jurisdictional conferences follow them to their new connectional conference. - Institutions can choose to relate to one or more connectional conferences, as their bylaws allow.	No changes unless they choose to do so within the bounds of their bylaws	No changes
Finance & Pensions	- Requires churches that leave to pay their proportionate liability of unfunded pensions for their annual conference - Clergy that leave are removed from benefit and annuity risk pools and accrued benefits transferred to an individual investment account.	- Requires churches that leave to pay their proportionate liability of unfunded pensions for their annual conference - Clergy that leave are removed from benefit and annuity risk pools and accrued benefits transferred to an individual investment account. - Legal fees to navigate legacy connections - Wespath stays intact and works with connectional conferences. - Medical and pension liabilities remain the obligation of the annual conference. - Wespath will reassign pension liabilities for churches that opt to go with another connectional conference. - Annual conferences manage budgets to care for boundary reconfiguration costs.	- Requires churches that leave to pay their proportionate liability of unfunded pensions for their annual conference - Clergy that leave are removed from benefit and annuity risk pools and accrued benefits transferred to an individual investment account.	No changes
Episcopal Fund	No changes	- Salaries and benefits paid by the U.S. connectional conferences - No changes to central conference funding	No changes to central conference funding	No changes

Sources: Ask The UMC, Great Plains Conference, individual plan representatives and legislation